Janata Party (BJP). Three years later, the entire NCP spectrum sits at another crossroads. Or, since it's two parties in ideologically ambiguous opposition to each other and also beset by inner tensions, call it a clover-leaf intersection.

At one end, Pawar Sr's rump party, the NCP (SCP), is poised on the edge of a shift that runs counter to its history so far. At another, Ajit's faction, which retains the name NCP, is mired in an internal battle for control that seems to leave many paths open for both sides.

After Ajit's death in an air accident in Baramati this January, his widow Sunetra Pawar had emerged to helm the NCP and fill his place as deputy chief minister in the Devendra Fadnavis government. But her authority as national president is under challenge from a power duo: former Union minister Praful Patel and Lok Sabha MP Sunil Tatkare. The old guard, they had initially backed her. But soon enough, a serious jockeying for control began.



TWIN FLAMES NCP (SCP) chief Sharad Pawar and daughter Supriya Sule, Lok Sabha MP

MANDAR DEODHAR

PAWAR STEERING

Things are so fluid that even the idea of a merger was floated briefly, before Ajit's death put plans on the back-burner. The logic: if the NCP (SCP) too hitches its wagon to the saffron caravan, that would remove one chief point of division between the two sides. But could that happen? Through all his long years in politics, there was one thing Pawar Sr had never done. Despite his famed capacity for cross-party conversations, he had never partnered with the right-wing BJP—save during an early phase of anti-Congressism. When he became CM for the first time in 1978, his Progressive Democratic Front government included leaders from the BJP's predecessor, the Bharatiya Jana Sangh, who were part of the Janata Party. For almost three decades, as the Congress grew into a dominant force in Maharashtra politics, Pawar Sr, who returned to the party in 1986, had remained a reliable anchor of the secular side.

But barring the 31 months of the Maha Vikas Aghadi regime, his flock has been out of power since 2014—and the pressure was building. After holding out for a long time, Pawar Sr had reportedly taken himself right up to the threshold of the final step, in extended meetings with the ruling side. His daughter, Lok Sabha MP Supriya Sule, made herself visible in the space of dissent at Jantar Mantar. But alongside, the party displayed a certain ambidexterity, continuing negotiations with the government on pre-nuptial terms.

Had the delimitation bill been tabled in the monsoon session, consent may have become manifest.

Takeaways

- **NCP (SCP) on the brink of switching to BJP side**
- **Sunetra, Parth fight off Praful-Tatkare challenge**
- **Prashant Kishor adds twist; some want merger**

A senior NCP (SCP) functionary, speaking about the party's willingness to offer "issue-based support" to the BJP, made no bones about what a section of the party wants. "Our position is, why settle for just six MPs when you can get all nine?" he said. Six was the number of Lok Sabha MPs expected to switch sides, according to one plan. Nine is the total parliamentary strength of the NCP (SCP)—eight in the Lok Sabha, one in the Rajya Sabha.

If that has slipped back into an indeterminate grey, the other NCP's fate is no different. Just over six months after Ajit's death, it finds itself in the throes of a full civil war. In early July, a party functionary from Bihar, whose factional loyalties aren't hard to infer, formally challenged the procedure by which Sunetra was elected national president on February 26. Around month-end, the Election Commission flagged discrepancies in amendments Sunetra made to the party constitution, and sought authorising documents.